twenty years, he was sad to be *hors de combat*, even though there was no way he could have remained in the theatre of operations. He lost the use of his right arm; but fortunately, it was saved from amputation by timely medical attention. Seriously wounded soldiers were sent to hospitals in the UK or the south of France. Grandpa spent many months recuperating in a hospital in France on the Mediterranean coast. Once, his eyes gleaming, he told us, 'Asi te memaa samundar kande nangiya nahandia wekhian san!' (We saw European ladies bathing in the nude on the beaches). This was how and when the 'French connection' of our family commenced.

For the 'Mahrattas', the Mesopotamian campaign was an epoch-making phase of their impressive and ancient martial tradition of bearing arms. As a mark of honour for the regiment's impressive display of gallantry, steadfastness, and ability to withstand the harsh battlefield conditions and severe deprivations in the First World War, it was given the title of 'Light Infantry'. All the paltans (battalions) suffered heavy casualties; some had to be re-raised during the war itself, albeit with reinforcements from sister battalions and with fresh recruitment. It was during this campaign that the 117th Battalion, now the Fifth Battalion, was given the honorific title of 'Royal' for conspicuous gallantry and the most outstanding standards of conduct, discipline and dedicated service.

India – Punjab and Maharashtra, in particular – lost thousands of young men in foreign lands, for the British Empire, for a free world, for the glory of their 'paltan'. They lived and died for 'naam', 'nishaan', 'namak', 'dastur' and 'izzat' (their name, colours, loyalty, tradition and honour).These were simple, disciplined, sincere and hard-working men from rural backgrounds but when required, they could be ferocious fighters and second to none in gallantry. It wouldn't be wrong to say that they remain so even today.

---

[1] These were: the 103rd, 1 Maratha LI (Jangi Paltan), the 105th, 2 Maratha LI (Kali Panchwin), the 110th, 2 Para (converted from 3 Maratha LI), the 114th, presently the Maratha LI Regimental Centre (converted from 10 Maratha LI in 1922), and the 117th, 5 Maratha LI (Royal).